

# GIFT

GRANTS INDEX FOR TEXAS · METHODOLOGY · TAX YEAR 2023

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## GIFT Methodology

**GIFT, Grants Index For Texas.** Texas foundation giving, opened up, so your next funder is a search away.

Status: working draft, full top 100 per side run complete. Wording locked. All bracketed **TODO** markers are filled from the full run. See the amendment log at the end for the revision history.

This document has two parts. The Public Version explains GIFT in plain language for any reader. The Technical Version documents the full pipeline, sources, and rules for anyone who wants to audit or rebuild the index.

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## Public Version

### What GIFT is

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GIFT, Grants Index For Texas, exists to help Texas nonprofits find funders they can actually approach. It is built entirely from public IRS data, the annual returns that grantmaking organizations file, and it focuses on a single tax year, currently 2023, so every funder is measured on the same footing.

GIFT covers two kinds of funder, private foundations and grantmaking public charities. They are ranked separately because they file different returns and operate differently, and the top funders are shown on each side.

### What it takes to be included

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An organization is included when it is a real, approachable grantmaker. In plain terms that means four things.

It is reachable. Its money goes to outside organizations rather than only to itself or a single affiliate.

It chooses. It decides its own giving rather than passing predetermined money straight through.

It gives cash. Real grant dollars a nonprofit can use, not donated goods or services.

It is identifiable. It has a public identity you can research and contact.

For private foundations, which give by law and choose their grantees by design, those qualities come with the territory, so the only real question is reachability, whether the foundation funds beyond its own walls. For public charities, which are a mix of true funders and organizations that mostly run their own programs, the test does more work, and organizations that move money but cannot be approached are left out so the list stays useful.

## **What gets left out, and why**

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It is worth being specific about what gets left out, because some of these organizations move a great deal of money and a reader might reasonably wonder where they went. There are five reasons GIFT sets an organization aside.

A closed loop. The organization gives only to the parent it was created to serve, so the money never reaches the wider nonprofit world. For example, a university's own foundation that funds only its university, or a senior living company's charitable arm that supports only its own residents.

Running programs rather than making grants. The money is the organization's own operating budget. For example, a museum that funds its own exhibits, or a service that passes a donor's gift straight through to a recipient the donor already chose.

A closed network. The recipients are a fixed, certified membership that an outside nonprofit cannot join, so the money moves but a newcomer cannot get in. For example, the statewide network of certified court advocates.

Goods instead of cash. The organization distributes donated food or supplies rather than grant dollars a nonprofit can spend. This includes programs that pass federal nutrition funding to enrolled childcare providers, which are both a closed network and an in kind program at once.

No public identity. The organization cannot be found, verified, or contacted at all.

In the current public charity list, 40 organizations were set aside for one or more of these reasons, each recorded openly in a published audit file so anyone can check the call.

## **What each funder entry shows**

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For each funder, GIFT shows where the money went, the organizations it granted to and how much. This recipient detail is available for most funders. For some it is not, because the funder reported its grants as a separate attachment, as a single lump sum, or as donated goods rather than as an itemized list. In those cases

the funder still appears with its total giving, marked to show that a recipient breakdown was not available in its filing.

Where a foundation's filing states that it gives only to organizations it has already chosen and does not take unsolicited requests, GIFT notes that, so a nonprofit knows not to spend effort applying where the door is not open. Where the filing does not say, GIFT leaves it unmarked rather than guess, since a silent filing is not the same as a closed one.

## Where the data comes from

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Everything here comes from public records, reflects filings that run roughly a year behind, and is free to use. The data comes from the grantmaking returns that organizations file with the IRS, gathered from the IRS itself and from the GivingTuesday 990 Data Lake, an open archive of those filings. The index was built with open tools, the Python programming language, with Claude, an AI assistant, used to help write and check the code.

## Who makes GIFT

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GIFT is made by Jonathan Lin Davis as an independent public good. It is free to use, it takes no money, and it endorses no one. Figures run about a year behind the present and are refreshed quarterly.

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# Technical Version

**GIFT methodology, full pipeline.** Created and maintained by Jonathan Lin Davis, an independent public good. Authorship and licensing appear at the end of this part.

The technical version is organized in four parts. Part A defines what GIFT measures and the scope rules. Part B documents the inclusion standard and the exclusions it produced. Part C describes the attributes each funder entry carries. Part D records sources, methods, freshness, and licensing.

## Part A, what GIFT measures

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### A1. Purpose and unit

GIFT indexes Texas grantmaking organizations to help nonprofits identify reachable funders. The unit of ranking is the organization, measured by grants paid in a single tax year, currently tax year 2023, selected because it is the most recent year with complete filing coverage in the source data.

## **A2. Two populations, ranked separately**

GIFT ranks two filer types separately. Private foundations, which file Form 990PF, and grantmaking public charities, which file Form 990. They are kept on separate lists because the forms report grants differently and the two types operate differently in law and practice.

## **A3. Texas scope**

An organization is included if its Business Master File state is Texas, reconciled against its mailing address, which both keeps genuine Texas filers and catches mailing artifacts.

## **A4. Grant size floor**

Recipient level grants are reported at 10,000 and above.

## **A5. Cutoff**

Each side publishes its top 100 by grants paid.

# **Part B, the inclusion standard**

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## **B1. The four principles**

An organization is included only if it is reachable, discretionary, a cash grantmaker, and identifiable.

Reachability. Its giving flows to outside organizations rather than to itself or a single affiliate.

Discretion. It exercises ongoing choice over its giving rather than passing predetermined funds through.

Cash. It makes monetary grants rather than in kind contributions.

Identifiability. It has a distinct public identity that can be researched and contacted.

## **B2. How the principles apply by filer type**

Private foundations. Because a 990PF filer is by law a grantmaker that chooses grantees, discretion, cash, and transparency are satisfied by the filing type and require no per name screening. Reachability is the only active screen. It excludes a foundation only when its giving forms a closed loop, flowing entirely or predominantly to a parent or commonly controlled entity it exists to serve, such that the funds do not reach the independent nonprofit sector. The number of recipients a foundation funds does not bear on this, a foundation that gives to a single outside organization is reachable, and a corporate foundation is excluded only when it funds solely its own parent rather than merely because it carries a company name. Invitation only giving is not disqualifying, the door existing but being harder to open is still a door.

Public charities. Because 990 filers mix genuine funders with operators and pass throughs, all four principles are actively screened.

### **B3. Public charity exclusions, by basis**

In the published set, 40 organizations that would otherwise rank by grant volume are excluded, each for a documented reason recorded in the exclusion audit file. The bases, with counts by every principle an organization fails, are as follows. Because six organizations fail on two bases each and are listed under both, the basis figures total 46 and reconcile to 40 distinct organizations.

Closed loop to a controlled entity, the reachability failure, 15 organizations. The funder's giving flows entirely or predominantly to a parent or commonly controlled entity it exists to serve, so the money does not reach the independent nonprofit sector. Examples, the Texas A&M Foundation, which funds its own university system, and the Lifespace Foundation, which serves only the residents and staff of its parent senior living company. One of these, Trinity Christian Academy, also fails the cash principle.

Operators and conduits, the discretion failure, 9 organizations. Operators run their own programs, so the dollars are program expenses rather than grants, and conduits pass money through without exercising choice over recipients. Examples, the USS Lexington museum association, which operates its own museum, and DonateStock Charitable, a stock donation processor that routes proceeds to recipients the donor designates.

Closed certified or membership networks, 10 organizations. The recipients form a fixed, certified, or enrolled set that an outside organization cannot join, so even though money reaches multiple recipients, a grantseeker structurally cannot become one. Examples, Texas CASA and the Childrens Advocacy Centers of Texas, certified chapter networks. Five of the ten are USDA federal nutrition reimbursement programs that also fail the cash principle, noted under the next basis.

In kind rather than cash, 9 organizations. The organization distributes goods or services rather than grant dollars a nonprofit can spend. Examples, Trusted World, which distributes donated goods. Five of the nine are USDA Child and Adult Care Food Program reimbursement programs, such as Feeding Texas, that move federal nutrition dollars to enrolled providers, and these also fail the closed network principle. One, Trinity Christian Academy, also fails reachability.

No researchable public identity, the transparency failure, 3 organizations. The entity has no findable mission, leadership, or activity, or its filing identity does not match any researchable organization, so it cannot be verified or approached.

The complete list of excluded organizations, each with its EIN and documented basis, is published in the exclusion audit file that accompanies the index.

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## Part C, what each funder carries

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### C1. Application posture, displayed not filtered

Each funder carries an application posture field with two states, does not accept unsolicited requests, or unstated, derived from the 990PF filing. The field is read from a single checkbox in which a foundation declares that it makes contributions only to preselected organizations and does not accept unsolicited requests. This box is one directional in the source data, it is either checked, which is recorded as does not accept unsolicited requests, or absent, which is recorded as unstated. The filing carries no affirmative marker for accepting applications, because acceptance is represented by the absence of the box, which cannot be distinguished from a foundation that simply did not complete this part of the return. For this reason the field never asserts that a foundation accepts applications, it states only what the filing affirmatively declares. Unstated never implies closed, a blank is not a refusal. The field is informational only and never used to include or exclude, and it is reported as filed for the tax year, not as current live guidance. In the current private foundation set, 52 funders are marked does not accept unsolicited requests and 48 are unstated.

### C2. Recipient coverage and its limits

Recipient detail is extracted from each funder's return and is available for the large majority of funders. Across the indexed funders, recipient level detail was successfully parsed for 171 of 195 funders, 88 percent. Where recipient detail is not available, it is because the funder reported grants in one of three ways the structured filing does not itemize, as a separate attachment or schedule rather than in the return data, as a single lump sum total, or as noncash assistance such as donated goods rather than cash grants. Funders in this situation still appear in the index with their total giving and are marked to show that a recipient breakdown was not available in the filing. This is a limitation of how those organizations chose to file, not of the index, and the coverage marking makes it visible per funder rather than hidden.

### C3. Deduplication and entity handling

Filings are selected to prefer the grant bearing return when an organization filed more than one form in the year. Funders appearing under more than one EIN are resolved individually, the flagship entity retained and brand sharing supporting organizations judged on their own identity and reachability.

### C4. Recipient resolution

The index is browsable in two directions, from a funder to the organizations it granted to, and from a recipient to the funders that supported it. Building the recipient direction requires deciding when two grant records name the same organization. Recipient grants carry an EIN in about half of cases, so resolution uses the EIN as the trustworthy key where present, and where it is absent uses a deterministic normalization of

the recipient name combined with state. Normalization is rule based and reproducible, it uppercases, removes punctuation, standardizes common abbreviations, strips legal suffixes, removes a leading article, and drops a trailing city token that duplicates the city field. Two records merge only on an exact match after normalization, or when a name only record matches the normalized name and state of an EIN bearing record. No similarity scoring or fuzzy matching is used, because falsely combining two distinct organizations would misrepresent who funds whom, which is the central question the index answers. The method therefore under merges rather than over merges, a recipient may occasionally appear under more than one entry, but every funding relationship shown is one the filings actually report. Where the source filings themselves report different organizations under a shared EIN, the index reflects the filings as reported rather than overriding them.

A small number of grant records carry a placeholder in place of a recipient name, such as a reference to a separate attachment or schedule, used by funders that reported grants in bulk rather than itemizing. These are filing artifacts rather than organizations, and they are removed from the recipient views. The affected funders are the same ones marked as recipient detail unavailable, and they retain their total giving in the index.

## **Part D, sources, methods, and terms**

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### **D1. Data sources**

IRS Exempt Organizations Business Master File, Texas extract. The organization universe, names, classification codes, and Texas scope. File eo\_tx.csv, retrieved from [https://www.irs.gov/pub/irs-soi/eo\\_tx.csv](https://www.irs.gov/pub/irs-soi/eo_tx.csv).

IRS Statistics of Income annual extracts. The ranking financials, grants paid and total functional expenses, from the processing year file predominantly composed of tax year 2023 returns. The 990 and 990PF extract files, retrieved from the IRS Statistics of Income downloads at <https://www.irs.gov/statistics/soi-tax-stats-annual-extract-of-tax-exempt-organization-financial-data>.

GivingTuesday 990 Data Lake. The electronically filed Form 990 series return XML used for recipient level grants. Accessed through the Data Lake index of filings and the individual return XML it points to, hosted in public Amazon Web Services S3 storage and retrieved anonymously.

### **D2. Validation**

ProPublica Nonprofit Explorer and comparable public records were used to spot check individual organizations during the inclusion review, confirming identity, affiliation, and grantmaking behavior in borderline cases. These were a verification aid during construction, not a data source for the index, and no ProPublica data is incorporated into the published files.

### **D3. Tools, and how each was used**

Python, the programming language for the whole pipeline. Its standard library read the IRS comma separated value extracts, reconciled the Texas universe, applied the inclusion screens, ranked each side by grants paid, and parsed the return XML for recipient level grants, handling the IRS electronic filing namespace and branching by form type, the 990PF grants paid schedule for foundations and Schedule I for public charities.

A local command line terminal running Windows 11 and PowerShell, with Python 3.14, where every data run was executed against locally downloaded copies of the source files, so each step was reproducible and inspected before moving on.

Claude, an AI assistant from Anthropic, used during development to help write, diagnose, and verify the analysis and parser code, including identifying field mappings and data quality cases such as attachment only and noncash filings. All production runs were executed and reviewed by the author.

Formats handled. IRS comma separated value extracts for the organization and financial layers, IRS Form 990 series XML for recipient detail, output written as comma separated value files for the index.

### **D4. Freshness and refresh**

Filings run roughly a year behind, so the current index reflects tax year 2023. The index is refreshed manually on a quarterly basis, with each refresh reviewed before publication.

### **D5. Authorship, independence, and licensing**

GIFT is created and maintained by Jonathan Lin Davis. It is an independent public good, built and published in a personal capacity, and is not affiliated with, sponsored by, or endorsed by any agency, foundation, funder, or campaign. GIFT makes no endorsements of any organization it lists, inclusion reflects only the objective standard described above and never a judgment of merit. The underlying data is released under a Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 license, and the code under the MIT license, so the work can be freely reused, audited, and rebuilt by anyone.

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## **Amendment log**

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- v0.1 draft. Wording locked across both versions. Open items, fill the public charity exclusion list and count, fill recipient coverage figures, both from the full top 100 per side run, then verify every clause against the actual output before marking final.
- v0.2. Full top 100 per side run complete. Private foundation principle rewritten from the retired single beneficiary framing to the locked reachability standard, closed loop to a controlled entity, with recipient



count explicitly not bearing on inclusion and invitation only giving not disqualifying. Public charity exclusions filled, 40 distinct organizations excluded, presented by the five bases with counts by every principle an organization fails, six organizations failing two bases each shown under both, basis figures totaling 46 reconciling to 40 distinct. Public version expanded to walk through the five exclusion bases in plain language with an example of each. Recipient coverage filled, 171 of 195 funders parsed with recipient detail, 88 percent. Per category counts verified against the exclusion list before drafting. Private foundation side carries zero exclusions under the reachability standard. Full named exclusion roster with individual reasons maintained in the accompanying exclusion audit file.

- v0.3. Application posture extracted from the 100 private foundation filings. The 990PF marks only the preselected case, a single checkbox present as a checkmark or absent, with no affirmative marker for accepting applications. Posture narrowed from three states to two honest states, does not accept unsolicited requests and unstated, because acceptance cannot be distinguished from a blank filing. Public version posture sentence aligned to mark only the closed door and leave silent filings unmarked. Distribution, 52 of 100 funders marked does not accept unsolicited requests, 48 unstated. Posture written as a column on the private foundation list.
- v0.4. Document reorganized for readability. Public version broken into six scannable sections with headers. Technical version grouped into four lettered parts, Part A what GIFT measures, Part B the inclusion standard, Part C what each funder carries, Part D sources methods and terms, with scope rules consolidated in Part A. Wording preserved with light polish only, no rules changed.
- v0.5. Two directional views built from the recipient grant edges, funder to recipients and recipient to funders, plus a recipient summary. Recipient resolution documented in new section C4, EIN first then deterministic name and state normalization, no fuzzy matching, conservative under merge. From 16,950 edges, 7 filing placeholder rows removed, resolving to 10,259 distinct recipients, 6,160 keyed by EIN. Section C4 also documents placeholder handling and the treatment of organizations that share an EIN in source filings.